



U.S. AIR FORCE



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AFRL

TACTICAL Broad Agency Announcement (BAA) FA9451-24-S-0001 Briefing for Industry

Directed Energy Directorate 19 October 2023



Welcome!

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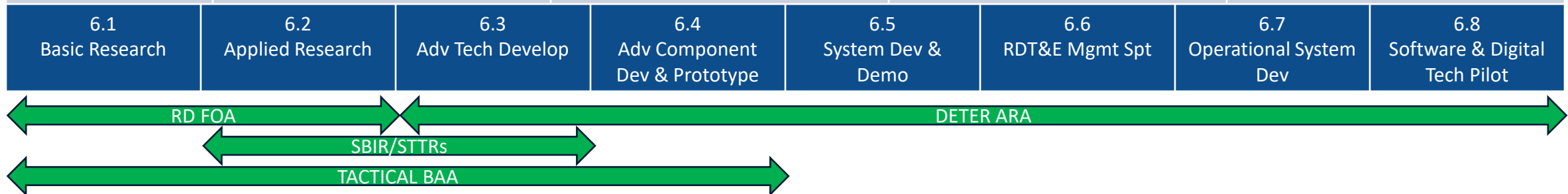
TACTICAL BAA Industry Day 2023 Agenda

- Overview of AFRL opportunities
- TACTICAL BAA Overview Presentation
 - Standard Call Process
 - Topic Area Groups (TAGs)
- Valid Eval
- Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ's)
- Review of Submitted Questions



Overview of AFRL Opportunities

Name:	RAD FOA	SBIR/STTRs	TACTICAL BAA	DETER ARA
Type of Awards:	Grants Cooperative Agreements	SBIR/STTR Sequential Phase II, Phase III *Phase I and II are managed through AF SBIR Office	FAR-based Awards	- OT for Research - OT for Prototype/Prod. - Procurement for Experimental Purposes - Prize Competitions
Guidance/ Regulation	DoDGARS & 2 CFR 200	FAR, SBIR Policy Directives	Federal Acquisition Reg. (FAR)	Primarily 10 USC 4023
Purpose:	Stimulate & Support Public Purpose	Foster SB development and commercialization	Advancing state-of-the-art or increasing knowledge	Fulfill Test/Experimentation Need
Required for Use:	Must be a research institution	- Must be a small business - For STTRs, must be partnered with a research institution	Must be for basic and applied research (6.1-6.4)	Must be for: - Supply/Part/Design - Experimental/Test Purpose - Minimum qty necessary
Budget Activities:	Primarily 6.1-6.2	Primarily 6.2-6.3	Primarily 6.1-6.4	Typically, 6.3 and above





Overview of AFRL Opportunities

Name:	RD FOA	SBIR/STTRs	TACTICAL BAA	DETER ARA
Advantages & Benefits:	Universities & research institutions very familiar with FOA process	• Uses SBIR/STTR Funding • Supports SB Goals • Well-known, phased program structure	• Streamlined evaluations via Valid Eval tool • Blanket AP/ASP & Coordinations completed • Pre-approved templates (CDRLs, AFMC 191, etc.)	• Max flexibility with structuring solicitations and awards • Ability to reach non-trationals
Potential Limitations:	Principal purpose must be to stimulate/support public purpose (not direct benefit of Gov).	• SBIR Data Rights (Prohibits disclosure for 20 years from initial award) • Limited to scope of SBIR/STTR Project	Cannot focus on specific system or hardware solution	Requires experienced team to award/manage non-FAR contracts. Limited to minimum quantity necessary for test/experimentation <u>May</u> require cost share or non-traditional involvement.
Preferred Tool for:	Awards to Universities & Research Institutions	Awards to Small Businesses with existing SBIR/STTR Projects	FAR-based awards for 6.1-6.4 R&D efforts	Non-FAR awards, non-traditional entities, or for efforts typically at 6.3+



TACTICAL General Information

- BAA Number: FA9451-24-S-0001
- NAICS Code: 541715 for Research and Development in the Physical, Engineering, and Life Sciences
- Small Business Size Standard: 1,000 employees
- Contracting Points of Contact: Daniel Jones/Bill Sherrod
- Due to the dynamically evolving nature of US warfighter directed energy needs, the TACTICAL announcement is subject to updates, revisions, and/or changes to the topic areas. Therefore, Offerors are highly encouraged to continually monitor <https://sam.gov> to ensure they receive latest guidance for this announcement.
- For Questions Please Email: afrl.rdlb.tacticalbaa@us.af.mil



TACTICAL BAA Overview

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FAR 35.016 Broad Agency Announcement

- This paragraph prescribes procedures for the use of the broad agency announcement (BAA) with Peer or Scientific Review (see 6.102(d)(2)) for the acquisition of basic and applied research and that part of development not related to the development of a specific system or hardware procurement. BAA's may be used by agencies to fulfill their requirements for scientific study and experimentation directed toward advancing the state-of-the-art or increasing knowledge or understanding rather than focusing on a specific system or hardware solution.
- Under this authority, TACTICAL will:
 - Provide innovative solutions and research and development (R&D) for Directed Energy (RD) laser sources, Aero-effects & Beam Control, laser system technologies, integration and demonstration, laser system modeling & simulation, laser interaction testing and modeling, laser vulnerability assessments, space domain awareness, High Power ElectroMagnetics/Microwaves (HPEM) modeling and effects, HPEM sources and components and applications, and wargaming efforts.



TACTICAL Acquisition Authority

- Approved blanket acquisition strategy for TACTICAL Broad Agency Announcement (BAA), pursuant to:
 - Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR)
- Complements existing acquisition tools - provides a responsive and flexible tool for meeting DE research requirements
 - \$499M Overarching Closed BAA with Calls And Topic Area Groups
 - Capable of FAR Awards only
 - 14 Topic Areas from across the entire AFRL/RD portfolio
 - Allows for funding as applicable under fiscal law to include 3600 RDT&E (primary), and 3400 O&M (as applicable)
 - RDT&E efforts 6.1 (basic research) through 6.4 (advanced component development and prototypes)
 - Projected award timelines of 100-135 days depending on solicitation method

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RD Technical Division Overview

- TACTICAL's 14 topic areas have scope to cover the entire AFRL/RD Portfolio
- RD Technical Divisions
 - Laser Systems
 - Modeling, Simulation, & Wargaming
 - High Power Electromagnetics
 - Space Electro-Optics
 - Joint Directed Energy Transition Office



TACTICAL Topic Areas

- I. Laser Sources
- II. Aero-Effects & Beam Control
- III. Laser System Technologies, Integration and Demonstration
- IV. Laser System Modeling & Simulation
- V. Laser Interaction Testing
- VI. Laser Interaction Modeling and Simulation (M&S)
- VII. Laser Vulnerability Assessments
- VIII. Satellite Custody and Characterization (SCC)
- IX. Identification (ID) and Characterization Using Alternate Electro-Optics (EO) Phenomenologies
- X. Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Autonomy for Space Domain Awareness (SDA)
- XI. High Power Electromagnetics (HPEM) Modeling and Effects
- XII. HPEM Sources and Components
- XIII. HPEM Applications
- XIV. Wargaming

These Topic Areas Encompass all of RD

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TACTICAL BAA

- This BAA announcement will include two Solicitation mechanisms
 - **CLOSED CALL ANNOUNCEMENTS**
 - Traditional BAA Call process - closed Calls announced on SAM.gov to solicit for white papers or proposals
 - Responses will be evaluated using streamlined evaluation tool (Valid Eval)
 - Various structures: One-Step, Two-Step, Phased/Staggered
 - **TOPIC AREA GROUPS (TAGs)**
 - Novel approach
 - Requests for Executive Summaries (ES) for TAG inclusion announced as a BAA amendment on SAM.gov
 - Groups are arranged by Topic Areas
 - Solicitations issued directly to the TAG as Letter Request for White Paper (RFPW) or Proposal (RFP)
 - Responses will be evaluated using streamlined evaluation tool (Valid Eval)
 - Various structures: One-Step, Two-Step, Phased/Staggered

*Gov't reserves the right to collapse a white paper/Two-Step into a One-Step if the situation warrants the white paper contains sufficient technical detail to do full Technical Proposal Evaluation instead of a white paper Evaluation.

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TACTICAL Industry Responses

TOPIC AREA GROUPS

- Executive Summaries (to establish TAG membership Only)
 - 2 Page Maximum
 - Includes: Description of “Technical Qualifications” (Expertise, Qualifications, Resources/Partnerships, etc.)
 - Requests issued on SAM.gov at least once per year, reserve the right for additional interim requests
 - Utilized ONLY to establish Topic Area Group membership
 - Executive Summaries submissions are by single Topic Area Group only – offerors must submit an ES for each Topic Area Group
 - Members will be asked annually to recertify their technical qualifications for group membership remain valid
 - Group membership remains valid for the life of the BAA unless not recertified by group member

CALLs and established TOPIC AREA GROUPS

- Submitted through Valid Eval as directed in the CALL or Letter RFP/RFWP
- White Paper
 - 5 Page Maximum (Not including cover page, draft SOW, or ROM) or as stated in the Call or Letter Request for White Paper
 - May only be submitted only in response to SAM.gov Call Announcement or TAG Letter RFP
 - Includes: Short Project/Technical description, Draft SOW, and Standardized ROM cost template
 - Can award directly from white paper if sufficient cost/technical information is included and an award decision is practicable
- Proposal
 - 20 Page Maximum (Not including cover page, draft SOW, or ROM) or as stated in the Call or Letter Request for Proposal
 - May only be submitted only in response to SAM.gov Call Announcement or TAG Letter RFP
 - Includes: Full Project/Technical Description, Draft SOW, Standardized Cost Model with Cost Proposal

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TACTICAL Calls

- Issued and managed directly by divisions for specific technical needs under defined Topic Areas
 - Calls will be issued under one primary Topic Area but could encompass multiple Topic Areas
- Various structures: One-Step, Two-Step, Staggered/Phased
- Gov reserves the right to collapse two-step process to one-step and to make awards directly from white papers if there is sufficient information within the white papers to make an award decision
- Includes a specific suspense date for responses



TACTICAL Topic Area Groups

- **Group Selection**
 - Groups will be organized by Topic Areas
 - Two-page Executive Summaries submitted by offerors will be reviewed and if determined to be “technically qualified,” will be included as an eligible member of that specific Topic Area Group.
 - Requests for Executive Summaries will be issued annually on or around 01 January
 - Offerors will be asked to recertify their Executive Summary annually on or around 01 December
 - Government reserves the right to issue additional interim requests for executive summaries as needed.
- **Group Membership**
 - Group membership will be active for the length of the BAA
 - Each selected Executive Summary only permits acceptance into the specific Topic Area Group proposed
 - Offerors must submit and have selected separate Executive Summaries to gain membership into multiple Topic Area Groups.
 - Group Members will be posted under SAM.Gov announcement by Topic Area



TACTICAL Topic Area Groups cont.

- **Group Solicitations**
 - Solicitations are issued to ALL Topic Area Group Members
 - Solicitations will typically consist of a Letter Request for Proposal (RFP) or Request for White Paper (RFPW)
 - Responses to the solicitation will be evaluated utilizing Valid Eval and the criteria stated in the BAA announcement
 - Responses must be categorized as Selectable or Highly Recommended to receive an award
 - Gov reserves the right to make one award, multiple awards, or no awards
 - Cost/Price Analysis may utilize any technique prescribed by FAR Subpart 15.4



Standard BAA Review and Eval Criteria

- Evaluations for white papers or proposals submitted under a Call will be conducted by a peer or scientific review process and will use the following criteria:
 - a) **Technical Merit:** Technical Merit is first in order of priority (more important than Relevance to AFRL Programs or Value/Cost) and shall be evaluated based on the following criteria, which are of equal importance
 - i. Overall scientific or technical merit
 - Problem statement, objectives and deliverables are clearly defined
 - Objectives and expected results are anchored by theory, analysis or data
 - Assumptions are logical, reasonable and appropriate
 - Offeror demonstrates knowledge of and applies state-of-the-art methods
 - ii. Soundness of the Offeror's technical approach
 - Approach is defined, logical and feasible
 - Schedule, speed of delivery (tech readiness date), and required resources are reasonable and appropriate
 - Proposed results are measurable and testable
 - Key staff have appropriate qualifications to perform proposed effort

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Standard BAA Review and Eval Criteria

b) Relevance to AFRL Programs: Outlined in topic area description

- i. Proposed effort is logically mapped to one or more topic area need(s)
- ii. Proposed effort provides valuable contribution to meeting one or more topic area need(s)
- iii. Benefits appropriately off-set identified risks

c) Value/Cost: Subject to funds availability

- i. For white papers: The ROM cost estimate will be evaluated on whether it is appropriate for the expected benefit and if sufficient funding is available. While papers that satisfy the technical merit factor, demonstrate benefits that are commensurate with the cost, and for which sufficient funding is determined to be available will be evaluated as best value to the Government.
- ii. For proposals: Cost will be evaluated on the degree to which it is realistic, reasonable and represents the best value to the Government. Cost realism will assess the likelihood that the proposed technical approach can be successfully accomplished for the cost proposed. Cost reasonableness will consider the cost proposed in conjunction with program objectives and availability of funding. Prior to award of a potential successful offer, the Contracting Officer will make a final determination regarding price reasonableness.



Award Process for Calls

- Notification of Award Decision
 - The CO/AO or CS will notify, in writing, any Offeror(s) selected for negotiation of potential award and Offeror(s) that was/were not recommended for award
 - Such notification will only occur after the technical peer or scientific review has been approved
 - The notification of recommendation for award is not to be construed to mean an award is assured, as availability of funds and successful negotiations are prerequisites to any award
- Under this BAA, more than one award may be made based on the quality of the proposals and availability of funding
- BAA method provides the flexibility to make an award for only those portions or tasks of the white paper or proposal that are of interest to the Government
- Awards will be made to Selectable / Highly Recommended proposals
 - Due to uniqueness of the BAA review process, it may be the case that while the overall white paper or proposal is ranked Not Selectable a certain part of it may be ranked Selectable / Highly Recommended



Communication

- Communication with Acquisition Team members is encouraged prior to the issuance of an RFP, after which time all communication must be submitted, in writing, to the Contracting Office
- Acquisition Team members cannot attempt to replace the potential Offeror's original ideas with their own ideas or the program office's preferred approach
- Acquisition Team members cannot share ideas or technical solutions provided in conversations, white papers, or proposals to a competing potential proposer or anyone else outside the team
- Any one-on-one communications are not a pre-screening process
- **NOTE: Pre-proposal communication procedures will be established at the Call level by the Contracting Officer**



Valid Eval

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Valid Eval Submission

- If responding to a Call or Letter RFP/RFWP, instructions for submitting to Valid Eval will be provided in the Call/Letter
- Please do not send White Papers or Proposals to the TACTICAL BAA Org Box
- Failure to send White papers through Valid Eval will cause delay or may result in your White Paper/Proposal not being reviewed
- Executive Summaries are not subject to the valid Eval process and will be submitted as directed on the BAA announcement amendment



Tips for Valid Eval

- The Team profile name you create must be unique
 - Valid Eval system will not allow for duplication of team profile names
 - Suggest considering some type of name/numbering scheme when submitting multiple papers
- One White Paper/Proposal per Team profile
- Ensure all fields in the Team profile are filled out correctly
- Refer to the TACTICAL BAA Industry Guide for the latest requirements on what should be addressed in your White Paper
- TACTICAL BAA Cover Sheet is still a required page to your White Paper submission
- Valid Eval only allows pdf/adobe files



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

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Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

- What are the benefits of the TACTICAL BAA?
 - Most streamlined approach for pursuing FAR-based awards for 6.1-6.4 efforts. 2.) Consolidating division level tools into a single directorate tool, reduces burden on acquisition personnel and contractor resources. Interested offerors will have one RD wide BAA to monitor on SAM.gov instead of multiple BAAs across the Directorate
- Why do we need another contracting tool separate from DETER?
 - Selecting the right contracting tool for the job leads to the best outcomes. TACTICAL BAA fills a gap for pursuing FAR-based awards for 6.1-6.4 efforts that was not available previously at the directorate level. TACTICAL will complement other tools such as the DETER ARA, SBIR/STTRs, and grants & cooperative agreements under the upcoming RAD Funding Opportunity Announcement (FOA).
- What if a technically qualified offeror wants to join a Topic Area Group, but missed the normal deadline?
 - The offeror can either wait and submit during the next annual period (every January) or AFRL can choose to release an interim request for additional executive summaries.
- Will these slides be available online or via email?
 - *The slide will be emailed to all registered participants, along with the Q&A, and will also be posted to the sam.gov DETER Virtual Industry Day announcement.*
- When will the next closed call be released?
 - *Please keep monitoring the TACTICAL SAM.gov posting and sign up for notification of changes. This will notify you when there are changes or a Call announcement is made under TACTICAL.*



Submitted Questions Review

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Technical Questions

- Question?
 - Answer